

‘The market isn’t going anywhere, Lala. Also, don’t make it obvious to Bina that the stock market will always be your first love,’ he said in one of his rare jovial moods.

After a two-week holiday, during which we toured Delhi and Himachal Pradesh, I was back at work. Screen-based trading had begun to pick up, despite the misgivings of the older generation of brokers. Initially, like most other traders, I was not happy at having to punch in trades on the screen. It made me feel more like a computer operator than a stock market player. Slowly, I overcame my reservations and warmed to the concept.

Watching the screen and the constant flickering of prices was an education in itself. I would look for patterns and try to guess which way prices were headed. Over the years, I could, with a reasonable degree of accuracy, figure out which operator was manipulating the prices too. In the initial days it had been hard to make out what was happening, as circular trading by cartels often presented a misleading picture of what was going on.

The trading bug slowly spread to retail investors too, now that they could get quotes in real time. Earlier, they were getting the quotes only at the end of the day. Easy access to prices led to many retail investors buying and selling more often than they otherwise had during the days of the trading ring.

Being with GB too made for education of a different kind. I admired his ability to keep cool in the most trying situations and liked the earthy wisdom he dispensed to people seeking his advice.

The promoter of a mid-sized pharma company (which would later grow to become one of the largest firms in the sector) once approached him with a problem.

‘Operator X is short-selling my shares almost on a daily basis,’ he told GB.

‘Is there something about the company that he knows but the market doesn’t?’ GB asked him.

‘There is nothing wrong with the business or the books, if that is what you mean,’ the promoter said.

‘If you want me to help you, be upfront. Only then can I give you the right solution. Have you pledged a big chunk of your shares with somebody?’ GB asked the promoter.